

WORKSHEET

Like rain upon the grass

Torah: Deuteronomy 32:1–52 · **Haftarah:** Hosea 14:2–10; Joel 2:15–27 · **Gospel:** Matthew 18:21–35

Moses' last song begins with the Word coming down like rain and sets the unchanging Rock against a heart that, in abundance, forgets from whom it received everything. Shabbat Shuvah (Hosea, Joel) calls to return — not to self-made fruit but to its Source — and Matthew 18 shows where that forgetting or returning becomes visible: in how you treat the other.

How to use this sheet

Work from top to bottom: first observe (A1), then weigh (A2), then diagnose (A3), and only then summarise (A4). The direction — receiving or forgetting — is the horizon, not the starting point.

Basic data

Parashah / scope: Ha'azinu — Deuteronomy 32:1–52. Haftarah (Shabbat Shuvah): Hosea 14:2–10 + Joel 2:15–27. Flanking reading and status: Matthew 18:21–35 — New Testament reflection, used confessionally (not as peshat). Audience: study group / congregation.

A1. Text blocks and peshat

Block	What it says (peshat)	Keywords / contrast	Open question
32:1–6	Heaven and earth as witnesses; rain/dew; the	witnesses · Rock	Do I begin with myself or with the Rock?

	Rock against a crooked generation.		
32:7–14	Remember; God found and carried like an eagle; abundance.	remember · eagle	Does God protect through movement?
32:15–18	Jeshurun waxed fat, forgot the Rock that begat him.	fat · forgetting	Why is abundance dangerous?
32:19–43	Judgment within faithfulness; “I kill and make alive, I heal.”	judgment · none other	Can judgment stand within faithfulness?
32:44–52	“No empty word, your life”; Moses to Nebo.	no empty word · Nebo	Do I myself stand under the Word?
Hos. 14 / Joel 2	Return; take words; dew; rend your heart; gather all.	shuv · heart ↔ garments	What is form, what is heart?
Matt. 18:21–35	Forgiven servant seizes fellow servant by the throat.	forgiveness · hard hand	Where does forgetting become visible?

A2. Connecting hypotheses

Hypothesis 1 (one axis): the centre is Source alone — all is gift; the human receives. History and response stay in the background.

Hypothesis 2 (relation): the centre is Source ↔ Trajectory, with a Coherence hinge — the unchanging Rock against a heart that forgets over time, and that forgetting becomes visible in how one treats the other (Matt. 18).

Which explains the most data with the least strain? Hypothesis 2. It explains the historical character of the song (Trajectory), the reversal when Jeshurun “waxed fat” (32:15), and why Matt. 18 was chosen. Hypothesis 1 leaves the reversal and the gospel unexplained.

What would refute this reading? If the song knew no reversal and Matt. 18 stood apart from the forgetting-motif, the weight would lie with Source

alone.

A3. Four axes

Axis	Text anchors	Diagnosis	Open anomaly
Source	32:2,4,18,39 · Hos. 14:5,8	Load-bearing. The Rock gives, carries, heals; “from Me your fruit.”	Why does He hide His face?
Trajectory	32:7–15 · 32:26–27 · Hos. 14:1	Load-bearing. Found → fat → forgotten → judged → returned.	Abundance or wilderness the greater test?
Coherence	32:18 · Joel 2:13 · Matt. 18:32–33	Hinge. Forgetful heart hard hand.	Does Matt. 18 serve the centre?
Will	32:1,46–47 · Hos. 14:2	Response, not source: listen, return, take words.	Where does returning become a project?

A4. Movement

What is unmasked? Forgetting the Rock in abundance — receiving that turns into possessing — and the treacherous idolatry that does not reject God but makes Him practically unnecessary; visible in the hard hand toward the neighbour (Matt. 18).

What frame does the text put in its place? The unchanging Rock who gives and heals; teshuvah as looking again at Him, and “from Me is your fruit found.”

What concrete response and formation follow? Listen (ha'azinu); return with words (Hosea); rend your heart, not your garments (Joel); and let the received forgiveness open the hand toward the other (Matt. 18).

Core sentence: The Rock does not change; the heart forgets — return, and let the grace you received open the hand you stretch out to your brother.

Horizon (ground, not the week's theme): “I kill and I make alive, I heal” (32:39) and “from Me your fruit” (Hos. 14:8) — the restoration comes from the Rock, not from our achievement.